

Qi-Tonifying Herbs

Tonic Herbs – Overview

Tonic herbs strengthen the body's vital substances, including **qi, blood, yin, and yang**. They are used to restore physiological function, support constitutional weakness, enhance immune resistance, and promote recovery from chronic illness.

Major Categories of Tonic Herbs

- **Qi-tonifying herbs:** Strengthen the Spleen and Lung to improve transformation, transportation, and respiration.
- **Yang-tonifying herbs:** Warm and supplement Kidney yang and may secondarily support Spleen and Heart yang.
- **Blood-tonifying herbs:** Nourish and replenish blood, primarily affecting the Liver, Heart, and Spleen.
- **Yin-tonifying herbs:** Nourish yin and generate fluids, most commonly targeting the Kidney and Liver, with secondary effects on the Lung and Stomach.

Common Deficiency Combinations

- Qi and yang deficiency
- Qi and blood deficiency
- Qi and yin deficiency
- Yin and blood deficiency
- Yin and yang deficiency

General Cautions for Tonic Herbs

- Qi tonics are **sweet and cloying** and may cause dampness or stagnation in the Middle Jiao.
- Yang tonics are **warm and drying** and may damage yin or aggravate heat.
- Blood and yin tonics may be **heavy or greasy**, impairing digestion.

Pharmacological Correlates

- Immunomodulatory
- Adaptogenic
- Endocrine-regulating
- Metabolic
- Cardiovascular supportive

Potential Herb–Drug Interactions

- Immunosuppressive agents
- Hormonal therapies
- Cardiovascular medications
- Corticosteroids (e.g., dexamethasone)

Qi-Tonifying Herbs – General Characteristics

Attribute	Description
Taste	Sweet
Temperature	Warm (generally)
Channels	Spleen, Lung
Primary Actions	Tonify qi, strengthen digestion and respiration

Qi-Tonifying Herbs – Quick Reference Table

Herb	Nature	Channels	Core Exam Keywords
Ren Shen <i>Radix ginseng</i>	Warm	LU, SP	Strongly tonifies Yuan Qi; rescues collapse; generates fluids; calms Shen
Xi Yang Shen <i>Radix panacis quinquefolii</i>	Cold	HT, LU, KD	Tonifies qi and yin; clears heat; generates fluids
Dang Shen <i>Radix codonopsis</i>	Neutral	LU, SP	Tonifies Middle Jiao qi; generates fluids; nourishes blood
Tai Zi Shen <i>Radix pseudosterllariae</i>	Neutral	LU, SP	Mild qi tonic; for weak or pediatric patients
Huang Qi <i>Radix astragali</i>	Slightly warm	LU, SP	Raises yang; tonifies Wei Qi; promotes pus discharge
Bai Zhu	Warm	SP, ST	Tonifies SP; dries damp; stops

Herb	Nature	Channels	Core Exam Keywords
<i>Atractylodis macrocephalae</i>			sweating; calms fetus
Shan Yao <i>Rhizoma dioscoreae</i>	Neutral	LU, SP, KD	Tonifies qi and yin; stabilizes essence
(Bai) Bian Dou <i>Semen lablab album</i>	Slightly warm	SP, ST	Strengthens SP; transforms damp; summer-damp
Ci Wu Jia <i>Radix et caulis acanthopanacis senticosi</i>	Warm	HT, SP, KD	Tonifies qi; calms Shen; strengthens sinews
Gan Cao <i>Radix glycyrrhizae</i>	Neutral/Warm	All	Tonifies qi; harmonizes; clears fire toxin
Da Zao <i>Fructus jujubae</i>	Neutral	SP, ST	Tonifies qi and blood; moderates harsh herbs
Geng Mi <i>Semen oryzae</i>	Cool	SP, ST	Protects Middle Jiao; thirst and irritability
Yi Tang <i>Saccharum granorum</i>	Slightly warm	LU, SP, ST	Tonifies Middle Jiao; alleviates pain
Feng Mi <i>Mel</i>	Slightly warm	LU, SP, LI	Moistens Lung and Intestines; stops cough

Rén Shēn 人參 (Radix Ginseng)

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, slightly bitter, slightly warm

Channels: Lung, Spleen

Actions

- Strongly tonifies Yuan (Source) Qi and rescues collapse

- Collapse due to profuse sweating, vomiting, diarrhea, hemorrhage, or chronic illness
- **Tonifies Spleen qi**
 - Fatigue, poor appetite, diarrhea, prolapse
- **Tonifies Lung qi**
 - Shortness of breath, weak respiration, wheezing
- **Generates fluids and alleviates thirst**
 - Xiao Ke; febrile disease injuring qi and fluids
- **Calms the Shen and supports cognition**

Indications

- Collapse of Yuan (Source) qi after profuse sweating, vomiting, diarrhea, hemorrhage, or chronic illness
- Extreme fatigue, weak pulse, cold extremities, shallow respiration
- Spleen qi deficiency: poor appetite, abdominal distention, chronic diarrhea, prolapse
- Lung qi deficiency: wheezing, shortness of breath, weak respiration
- Thirst and Xiao Ke from injury to qi and fluids
- Mental fatigue, poor concentration, and insomnia from qi deficiency

Dosage

- 5–10 g (general), 1–2 g (powder)
- 15–30 g for collapse
- Usually decocted separately at lower temperatures

Contraindications

- Excess or heat patterns
- Incompatible with **Li Lu** (*Rhizoma et Radix Veratri Nigri*)
- Antagonized by **Zao Jiao** (*Fructus Gleditsiae*)
Counteracted by **Wu Ling Zhi** (*Troglodytes xanthipes*) and **Lai Fu Zi** (*Raphanus sativus*)
- Avoid with turnips, daikon, green tea

Xī Yáng Shēn 西洋参 (*Radix Panacis Quinquefolii*)

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, slightly bitter, cold

Channels: Heart, Lung, Kidney

Actions

- **Tonifies qi and nourishes yin (Lung)**
 - Qi and yin deficiency after warm-febrile disease
- **Clears deficiency heat**
 - Irritability, low-grade fever, dry mouth
- **Generates fluids and alleviates thirst**
 - Xiao Ke, post-febrile dryness

Indications

- Qi and yin deficiency after warm-febrile disease
- Lung yin deficiency with heat: cough, wheezing, blood-streaked sputum
- Deficiency heat: irritability, low-grade fever, dry mouth
- Thirst and Xiao Ke from fluid depletion

Dosage

- 3–6 g
- Often decocted separately
- Can be used individually

Contraindications

- Cold-damp or Spleen yang deficiency
- Incompatible with **Li Lu** (*Rhizoma et Radix Veratri Nigri*)

Dǎng Shēn 党参 (Radix Codonopsis)

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, neutral

Channels: Lung, Spleen

Actions

- **Tonifies Middle Jiao qi**
 - Fatigue, poor appetite, chronic diarrhea
- **Tonifies Lung qi**
 - Chronic cough, SOB, copious sputum
- **Tonifies qi and nourishes blood**
 - Dizziness, palpitations, pale complexion

- **Generates fluids**
 - Thirst, Xiao Ke

Indications

- Spleen qi deficiency: fatigue, poor appetite, diarrhea, vomiting
- Lung qi deficiency: chronic cough, shortness of breath, copious sputum
- Qi and yin deficiency after febrile disease with thirst and irritability
- Blood deficiency: dizziness, pale complexion, palpitations

Dosage

- 10–30 g

Contraindications

- Incompatible with **Li Lu** (*Rhizoma et Radix Veratri Nigri*)

Exam Pearl

Substitute for Ren Shen in **non-collapse** qi deficiency.

Tài Zǐ Shēn 太子参 (Radix Pseudostellariae)

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, slightly bitter, neutral

Channels: Lung, Spleen

Actions

- **Gently tonifies Spleen and Lung qi**
 - Weak, frail, or pediatric patients
- **Generates fluids**
 - Post-febrile thirst

Indications

- Mild Spleen and Lung qi deficiency in weak or frail patients
- Post-illness fatigue during recovery
- Thirst and fluid injury after febrile disease
- Pediatric and elderly qi deficiency when stronger tonics are not tolerated

Dosage

- 10–30 g

Contraindications

- Insufficient alone for severe deficiency

Exam Pearl

Ideal for **children, elderly, or very weak patients.**

Huáng Qí 黄芪 (Radix Astragali)

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, slightly warm

Channels: Lung, Spleen

Actions

- **Tonifies qi and raises yang**
 - Prolapse, chronic diarrhea
- **Tonifies Wei qi and stabilizes the exterior**
 - Spontaneous sweating
- **Promotes discharge of pus and generates flesh**
 - Chronic sores
- **Promotes urination and reduces edema**

Indications

- Spleen and Lung qi deficiency with fatigue and loose stools
- Prolapse of uterus, stomach, or rectum from sinking qi
- Spontaneous sweating from Wei qi deficiency
- Chronic sores or ulcers that do not heal
- Edema due to qi deficiency

Dosage

- 10–15 g (up to 60–120 g in severe deficiency)
- Honey-fried enhances interior tonification

Contraindications

- Exterior pathogens present
- Excess, dampness, food stagnation
- Heat-toxin sores

Exam Pearl

Think “**Raise, Guard, Heal**”.

Bái Zhú 白朮 (Rhizoma Atractylodis Macrocephalae)

Nature & Flavor: Bitter, sweet, warm

Channels: Spleen, Stomach

Actions

- **Tonifies Spleen qi**
 - Fatigue, loose stools
- **Dries dampness and eliminates water**
- **Stabilizes the exterior and stops sweating**
- **Calms the fetus**

Indications

- Spleen qi deficiency: fatigue, bloating, diarrhea
- Dampness accumulation from weak transformation
- Spontaneous sweating from qi deficiency
- Restless fetus due to Spleen deficiency

Dosage

- 5–15 g

Contraindications

- Yin and fluid deficiency, Xu heat
- Qi stagnation with fullness

Processing Differences

- **Sheng Bai Zhu (unprocessed):** stronger for drying dampness and eliminating water accumulation
 - **Chao Bai Zhu (dry fried):** stronger qi tonification, stabilizes pregnancy, and stopping perspiration
 - **Jiao Bai Zhu (charred):** stops diarrhea
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Shān Yào 山药 (Radix Dioscoreae)

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, neutral

Channels: Kidney, Lung, Spleen

Actions

- **Tonifies qi and nourishes yin**
- **Tonifies Lung qi and yin**
 - Chronic cough
- **Tonifies Kidney and stabilizes essence**
- **Treats Xiao Ke**

Indications

- Spleen and Stomach qi deficiency with diarrhea and poor appetite
- Lung qi and yin deficiency with chronic cough or wheezing
- Kidney deficiency with spermatorrhea, frequent urination, leukorrhea
- Xiao Ke (wasting and thirsting disorder)
- Long-term qi and yin deficiency

Dosage

- 10–30 g (up to 250 g decoction)
- 6–10 g (powder form)

Contraindications

- Excess heat
- Damp accumulation without modification

Processing Differences

- **Sheng Shan Yao (fresh, unprocessed):** stronger for tonifying yin
- **Chao Shan Yao (dry fried):** stronger to strengthen Spleen, Lung, Kidney

Exam Pearl

Only qi tonic that **also strongly stabilizes**.

(Bai) Biǎn Dòu 扁豆 (Semen Lablab Album)

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, slightly warm

Channels: Spleen, Stomach

Actions

- **Strengthens the Spleen**
- **Transforms dampness and harmonizes Middle Jiao**

Indications

- Chronic diarrhea and poor appetite from Spleen deficiency
- Vaginal discharge due to Spleen deficiency
- Summer-damp patterns with vomiting or diarrhea

Dosage

- 10–20 g (decoction) max. dose is 50 g (Benskey-9-30g)
- 6-10g (powder)

Contraindications

- Ineffective alone for severe qi deficiency
- Do not take without cooking

Processing Differences

- **Sheng Bian Dou (fresh, unprocessed):** stronger for nourishing the Spleen and dispelling summer-dampness
 - **Chao Bian Dou (dry fried):** stronger to strengthen Spleen and relieve diarrhea
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Cì Wǔ Jiā 刺五加 (Radix et Caulis Acanthopanax Senticosi)

Nature & Flavor: Acrid, slightly bitter, warm

Channels: Heart, Spleen, Kidney

Actions

- **Tonifies qi and** strengthens Spleen & Kidney
- **Strengthens sinews and bones**
- **Calms Shen**

Indications

- Fatigue, low energy, and weakness of Spleen and Kidney
- Low back and knee soreness from Kidney deficiency
- Insomnia, disturbed sleep, and restlessness

Dosage

- 9–20 g (decoction)

Contraindications

- Internal heat or yin deficiency

Gān Cǎo 甘草 (Radix Glycyrrhizae)

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, neutral (raw); sweet, warm (fried)

Channels: All 12

Actions

- **Tonifies Spleen qi**
- **Moistens Lung and stops cough**
- **Clears heat and fire toxicity**
- **Moderates spasms and alleviates pain**
- **Harmonizes other herbs**

Indications

- Spleen qi deficiency: fatigue, loose stools, poor appetite

- Cough and wheezing from Lung deficiency or heat
- Carbuncles, sore throat, food or herb poisoning
- Abdominal or muscle spasms and cramping
- Harmonizing harsh or toxic herbs in formulas

Dosage

- 3–10 g (up to 30 g)

Contraindications

- Dampness, edema, hypertension, hypokalemia
- Incompatible with Gan Sui, Da Ji, Yuan Hua, Hai Zao
- Larger doses or chronic use can lead to elevated blood pressure and should not be used in cases of edema, kidney disorder, hypokalemia (low potassium), hypertension, or congestive heart failure

Processing Differences

- **Sheng Gan Cao (fresh, unprocessed):** stronger for clearing fire, eliminating toxins, moistening the Lung, and stopping cough
- **Chao Gan Cao (dry fried):** sweeter and warmer it tonifies the Spleen and benefits qi

Dà Zǎo 大枣 (Fructus Jujubae)

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, neutral

Channels: Spleen, Stomach

Actions

- **Tonifies Spleen qi**
- **Nourishes blood and calms Shen**
- **Harmonizes harsh herbs**

Indications

- Spleen and Stomach qi deficiency: weakness, poor appetite, loose stools
- Blood deficiency with irritability and poor sleep
- Emotional instability and Zang Zao disorder
- Moderating harsh herbs in formulas

Dosage

- 3–12 fruits or 10–30 g

Contraindications

- Damp-heat, heat, and phlegm-heat
 - Intestinal parasites
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Gēng Mǐ 梗米 (Semen Oryzae)

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, cool

Channels: Spleen, Stomach

Actions

- **Protects and strengthens Middle Jiao**
- **Treats thirst, irritability**

Indications

- Fatigue, diarrhea, thirst, and irritability from Middle Jiao deficiency
 - Protection of Stomach qi from harsh or cold herbs
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Yí Táng 饴糖 (Saccharum Granorum)

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, slightly warm

Channels: Lung, Spleen, Stomach

Actions

- **Tonifies Middle Jiao qi and alleviates pain**
- **Moistens Lung and stops cough**

Indications

- Middle Jiao deficiency with abdominal pain and cold
- Spleen qi deficiency from overwork
- Dry, weak cough from Lung deficiency

Dosage

- 15–60 g -Do not cook in decoction, take with the strained decoction.

Contraindications

- Dampness, phlegm, heat
 - Pediatric parasitic disorders
 - Cough caused by hot phlegm
 - Use with caution in patients with MJ dampness
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Fēng Mì 蜂蜜 (Mel)

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, slightly warm

Channels: Lung, Spleen, Large Intestine

Actions

- **Tonifies Middle Jiao and alleviates pain**
- **Moistens Lung and stops cough**
- **Lubricates Intestines**

Indications

- Abdominal pain and fatigue from Middle Jiao deficiency
- Chronic or dry cough from Lung deficiency
- Constipation from dryness or lack of fluids
- Supportive preparation for topical and internal formulas

Dosage

- 15–30 g -Do not cook in decoction, take with the strained decoction.

Contraindications

- Dampness, loose stools/diarrhea, bloating
-